European Commission

*Research and Innovation*



# EUROPEAN RESEARCH & INNOVATION DAYS

*Conference Report*
*September 2025*

EUROPEAN COMMISSION

# European Research & Innovation Days

## Conference Report

*September 2025*

**European Research & Innovation Days - Conference Report - 2025**

European Commission
Directorate-General for Research and Innovation
Unit F4 — Communication

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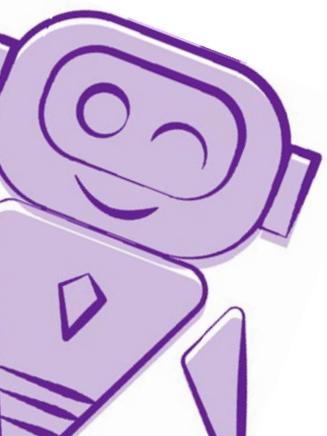
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# Introduction



EUROPEAN
RESEARCH & INNOVATION
DAYS 2025

Relive the sixth edition of the European Research and Innovation Days, the Commission's flagship event, bringing together policymakers, researchers, stakeholders and business leaders to debate and shape the future of research and innovation in Europe and beyond. The 2025 edition took place at a pivotal moment for discussions on the EU's next long-term budget and major policy files.

**5,300 participants** | **69 speakers 23 sessions** | coming from **23 different countries.** | Almost **10,000 online** live views

With over 20 sessions across two days, the programme explored Europe's competitiveness and industrial leadership, including debates on the Startup and Scaleup Strategy, the European Life Sciences Strategy, the AI in Science Strategy and the European Innovation and European Research Area Acts. High-level panels, hands-on breakouts and focused networking connect policy with real-world impact.

## Wide presence across social media:

Impressions : **825,679** Media views : **60, 143** Engagement : **14 096**

The event started with a keynote by **Commission President Ursula von der Leyen** and opening remarks by **Commissioner for Startups, Research and Innovation Ekaterina Zaharieva**, alongside leading speakers from EU institutions, science and industry such as **Executive Vice-President Henna Virkkunen** and **author and science communicator Lucy Hawking.**

## Successful partnerships with major outlets:

Finanial Times banners: **194.029 unique users** reched

Politico sponsorship of Brussels Playbook: **25%** of R&I Days **web page traffic** generated

Euronews policy debate with Cssr Zaharieva: **74,000 views**

Euractiv sponsoship of The Capitals: **133,000 impressions**

PANORAMIC AI:
Number of **visitors: 274**
Total number of **interactions with AI: 212**

# Keynote – President von der Leyen



**Ursula VON DER LEYEN**
*President of the European Commission*

Last year, I was in CERN, a monument of European innovation and collaboration. A scientist there said something that stayed with me:

“We are not here to do the impossible. We are here to do the unthinkable.”

In one sentence, he captured something central to Europe’s spirit. Our commitment to scientific discovery. Our relentless curiosity. Our drive to explore the unknown.

This Commission is determined to make Europe the best place in the world for research and innovation. Because we know that every breakthrough begins with a brilliant mind. And we want those minds to choose Europe.

# Opening remarks – Commissioner Zaharieva

Michael Faraday was allegedly asked what the use of his discoveries on electromagnetism was. He is supposed to have replied: ‘What is the use of a newborn baby?’ Of course, the answer is: Potential. Promise. The Future. But that potential didn’t remain theoretical. Faraday’s curiosity about invisible forces laid the foundation for electric motors, transformers, and the entire modern power grid. It is in that partnership, between curiosity and application, that science delivers its greatest gifts to society.

With your relentless curiosity and innovation drive, we can ensure that open-ended questions continue to reshape the world. Thank you to everyone who shared their time, experience and ideas. The R&I days were a great opportunity to meet face to face. To hear your ideas. To discover the projects that are changing Europe, driven by your talent and our funding. Thank you to everyone who shared their time, experience and ideas.



**Ekaterina ZAHARIEVA**
*European Commissioner for Innovation, Research, Culture, Education and Youth*

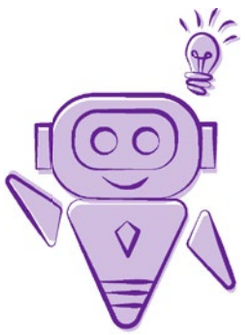
# Beyond the Horizon: future funding for R&I

EUROPEAN RESEARCH & INNOVATION DAYS 2025

In a rapidly evolving world, the future of European research and innovation funding stands at a pivotal crossroads, with the Horizon Europe programme at the centre. Proposals to significantly increase funding—potentially doubling or even tripling—aim to retain Europe's top talent and accelerate the growth of promising startups. This includes streamlining funding processes and strengthening coordination between European and national R&I initiatives, ensuring efficient use of resources. Strategic investments are essential to address urgent societal challenges, from improving public health to spearheading climate action, all while ensuring the sustainable management of natural resources. In this process, the role of the private sector is vital in fostering robust partnerships that drive innovation. By cultivating an environment that attracts and nurtures startups and scaleups, Europe positions itself to lead on the global stage as a powerhouse of research and innovation, committed to excellence and sustainable growth.

*I think that China and the US are right now locked in a, I would almost say, a brutal or a ruthless race for the mastery of AI and for the dominance of AI. And I think it is so important that Europe, with its democratic and its scientific values, is part of this conversation to make sure that we are not locked in a chicken race. But in order to be there, we also need to be part of the development, and we're not there.*

**Sylvia SCHWAAG SERGER**



## Moderator

**Méabh MC MAHON**
*Anchor | Euronews*

## Speakers

**Ekaterina ZAHARIEVA**
*European Commissioner for Startups, Research and Innovation | European Commission*

**Sylvia SCHWAAG SERGER**
*President | Royal Swedish Academy of Engineering Sciences*

**Eva-Maria HOLZLEITNER**
*Federal Minister for Women, Science and Research | Republic of Austria*

Image order: top to bottom and left to right



EUROPEAN RESEARCH & INNOVATION DAYS

R&I Days

# PROGRAMME

Hybrid Event: Brussels & Online

**16 SEPTEMBER 2025**

*All sessions will be live streamed on YouTube and R&I Community platform*

| Time slot | GOLDEN HALL (1000P) | SILVER HALL (300P) | COPPER HALL (500) |
|---|---|---|---|
| **OPENING** | | | |
| 14:00 | **Opening Day 1** | Streaming of the session | Streaming of the session |
| 14:00 – 14:10 | **Keynote President von der Leyen** | | |
| 14:10 – 14:20 | **Opening remarks Commissioner Zaharieva** | | |
| 14:20 – 15:05 | **Beyond the Horizon: future funding for R&I** | | |
| 15:05 – 15:15 | | | |
| | **CHOOSE EUROPE TO START AND SCALE** | | |
| 15:15 – 16:00 | **Building a Startup Powerhouse: The European Startup and Scaleup Strategy** | | |
| 16:00 – 16:30 | COFFEE BREAK | | |
| 16:30 – 17:00 | | **Research and technology infrastructures as catalysts for European Startup and Scaleup** | **Scaleup funding for Europe's competitiveness** |
| 17:00 – 17:10 | | | |
| 17:10 – 17:40 | | **A European "ARPA" approach - funding breakthrough innovations in Europe** | **Dual-use research and innovation: opportunities and challenges** |
| 17:40 – 18:00 | | | |
| 18:00 – 18:30 | **AI-powered research: a competitiveness opportunity for Europe** | | |
| 18:30 | **Closing of the Opening day** | | |

Time zone: CET



EUROPEAN RESEARCH & INNOVATION DAYS

R&I Days

PROGRAMME

Hybrid Event: Brussels & Online

**17 SEPTEMBER 2025**

*All sessions will be live streamed on YouTube and R&I Community platform*

| Time slot | GOLDEN HALL (1000P) | SILVER HALL (300P) | COPPER HALL (500) |
|---|---|---|---|
| **OPENING** | | | |
| 09:00 | **Opening Day 2** | Streaming of the session | Streaming of the session |
| | **SECURING EUROPE'S PLACE AT THE FOREFRONT OF SCIENTIFIC DISCOVERY** | | |
| 09:00 – 09:40 | **Making the EU the most attractive place for Life Sciences** | | |
| 09:40 – 10:00 | | | |
| 10:00 – 10:30 | **Securing Europe's place at the forefront of scientific discovery** | **Strengthening the EU clinical research ecosystem** | **Let's talk business – how to commercialise breakthrough research** |
| 10:30 – 11:00 | | COFFEE BREAK | |
| 11:00 – 11:30 | | **Cities of tomorrow** | **Building the Resource for AI Science in Europe (RAISE)** |
| 11:30 – 11:45 | | | |
| 11:45 – 12:15 | **Science Communication** | | |
| 12:15 – 13:30 | | LUNCH BREAK | |
| 13:30 – 14:00 | **Driving R&I Forward: roadblocks and accelerators for the EU automotive competitiveness** | | |
| | **MAKING A REALITY OF THE EU'S 'FIFTH FREEDOM' – RESEARCH, INNOVATION AND KNOWLEDGE** | | |
| 14:00 – 14:30 | **ERA Act, are we brave enough?** | | |
| 14:30 – 14:35 | | | |
| 14h35 – 15h15 | **Choose Europe for Science** | | |
| 15:15 – 15:40 | | COFFEE BREAK | |
| 15h40 – 16h10 | | **Protecting Academic Freedom worldwide: The role of Science Diplomacy and Research Security** | **€820 Billion on the Table: can Europe afford to ignore the Gender Gap in STEM careers?** |
| 16:10 – 16:30 | | COFFEE BREAK | |
| 16h30 – 17h15 | **Time's Up: Urgent Action Needed to Achieve the 3% R&D Investment Target** | | |
| 17h15 | **Conclusions** | | |

Time zone: CET


Live Sessions
16
SEPT
2025

# Building a Startup Powerhouse: The European Startup and Scaleup Strategy

EUROPEAN RESEARCH & INNOVATION DAYS 2025

Across the EU, 35,000 early-stage companies and 3,400 tech companies in their growth stage already drive innovation and creativity. But starting and scaling up innovative companies in Europe remains difficult today. From transitioning from lab to market, to accessing capital and talents, to a successful exit, European startups and scaleups still face challenges. That is why the EU Startup and Scaleup Strategy aims to make Europe the best place in the world to launch and grow global technology-driven companies.

This session reconciled the policy ambitions of EU policymakers with the on-the-ground experience of founders and industry experts. Founders shared concrete examples of the difficulties in securing financing, attracting skilled talent, and navigating fragmented markets. It was emphasised that, to compete globally, resources need to be pooled across the Union and that the role of public institutions as early customers of startups and scaleups should be strengthened. Participants agreed that Europe retains advantages in several key technologies, but that sustained urgency, a whole-of-government approach, and ongoing dialogue with stakeholders are essential to translate the Strategy's potential into success.

> We really have a chance to be the world leader in a lot of technologies, but if we win in the lab and lose in the marketplace or lose on Wall Street then all we're doing really is just preparing charity for US investors.
>
> **Clark PARSONS**

## Moderator

**Andras INOTAI**
*(Acting Head of the Taskforce on Startups and Scaleups and Head of the Innovation Policy and Access to Finance Unit in DG RTD | European Commission)*

## Speakers

**Elena MARTINES**
*Member of the Cabinet of Commissioner Zaharieva | European Commission*

**Hajdi CENAN**
*Co-founder and CEO | airt*

**Clark PARSONS**
*CEO | European Startup Network*

**Hedi MARDISOO**
*CEO and Co-Founder | Cachet*



Image order: top to bottom and left to right

# Research and technology infrastructures as catalysts for European Startup and Scaleup

EUROPEAN RESEARCH & INNOVATION DAYS 2025

Research and technology infrastructures hold the key to fuelling innovation and empowering European startups and scaleups. Instead of functioning merely as access points, these infrastructures must evolve into dynamic innovation hubs that nurture a diverse ecosystem. Unlocking the commercial potential of research requires raising awareness among researchers and creating robust funding frameworks to support their ventures. Yet, startups often struggle with the complexity, fragmentation, and uneven availability of these resources. To tackle these challenges, the European Startup and Scaleup strategy is set to boost investment, improve accessibility, and enhance coordination across infrastructures. Higher coordination will drive scientific breakthroughs, accelerate deep-tech innovation, and strengthen Europe's technological independence. Ultimately, creating an efficient infrastructure network for research and technology stands as a vital pillar of European science, fuelling entrepreneurship and shaping the future of innovation on the continent.

> Research and technology infrastructures are central to this transformation. They enable cutting-edge scientific discoveries, deep-tech innovation, support startups and reinforce Europe's technological sovereignty.
>
> **Signe RATSO**

## Moderators

**Signe RATSO**
*Deputy Director General | European Commission*

## Speakers

**Jesus VALERO**
*CEO | TECNALIA Research and Innovation*

**Massimo CACCIA**
*Full professor @UnInsubria - CEO @RandomPower | University of Insubria & Random Power ltd.*

**Plamena MARKOVA**
*Chief of International Relations | EMBL*



Image order: top to bottom and left to right

# Scaleup funding for Europeans competitiveness

EUROPEAN RESEARCH & INNOVATION DAYS 2025

Europe faces a critical challenge in scaling its own companies amid a funding landscape dominated by non-European capital, especially from the US and the Middle East. To boost competitiveness, the focus must shift toward nurturing homegrown global champions instead of acting as a launchpad for foreign investors. Creating strong markets for European technologies and encouraging large corporations to support startups through procurement and collaboration are essential steps. A vibrant financing ecosystem, blending public and private investments, is crucial to sustain growth at every stage. Initiatives like the Scale-Up Europe fund would play a key role in closing the funding gap and strengthening Europe's position on the world stage. Cross-European collaboration and building a robust investment environment are vital to unlocking the full potential of scaleups, ensuring Europe's future innovation and economic success.

> We've been talking about this Scale Up Europe fund, and for us, this is about going beyond the EIC model, which is a purely publicly funded model, to work with the private sector, because we think we can't get the scale of capital that we need unless we work with other investors, and we think we need to do this at European level.
>
> **Keith SEQUEIRA**

## Moderators

**Keith SEQUEIRA**
*Head of European Innovation Council Unit at DG RTD | European Commission*

## Speakers

**Soren NEDERGAARD**
*Chief Portfolio Officer | Novo Nordisk Foundation*

**Helen MCBREEN**
*Partner | Atlantic Bridge*



Image order: top to bottom and left to right

# A European “ARPA” approach – funding breakthrough innovations in Europe



Driving high-risk, high-reward innovation in Europe requires agile funding models inspired by the ARPA approach, prioritizing disruptive technologies that address real-world challenges. Demand-driven, milestone-based funding keeps projects focused and accountable, while active project management fosters breakthroughs by maintaining momentum and direction. Balancing program managers’ autonomy with structured oversight is essential to avoid bureaucratic delays without stifling creativity.

Early involvement of end-users ensures innovations meet actual needs, increasing their impact and adoption. Although resource-intensive, such models benefit from a diverse funding ecosystem rather than dependence on a single large agency, providing flexibility and resilience. They would also positively impact sensitive investments in the context of dual-use research, ensuring broader intellectual property and promoting collaboration between public and private sectors. This combined effort can accelerate technological advancements, strengthen Europe’s innovation landscape, and enhance its global competitiveness by supporting transformative projects that shape the future.

Moderator

**Anne-Marie SASSEN**
*Head of Unit of the Programme Managers Office | European Innovation Council and SME Executive Agency*

Speaker

**Christian HUMMERT**
*Scientific Director of Cyberagentur | Cyberagentur*

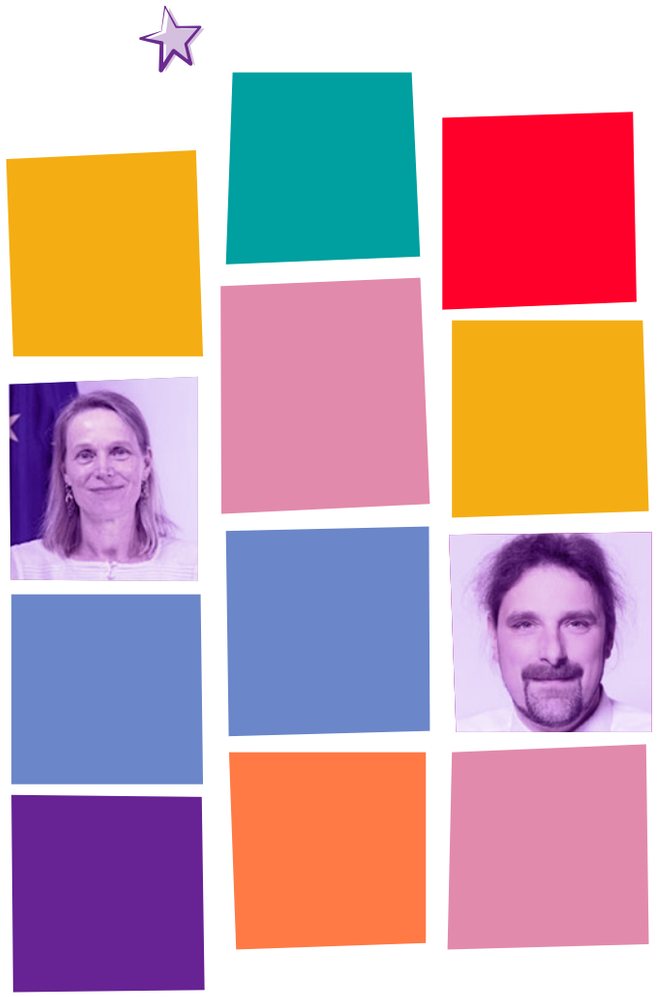


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I think the EIC has three main challenges right now. One is the scale-up. I think the budget of the EIC tripled to this year and it will still grow. The second one is the change of domains, because the ESC will also open for dual-use research. And the third one is new methods.

**Christian HUMMERT**

# Dual-use research and innovation: opportunities and challenges

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In a world of accelerating innovation and intensifying geopolitical instability, participants highlighted that dual-use research and innovation (R&I) is no longer optional but essential for Europe's competitiveness, resilience, and defence.

Speakers noted that innovation is increasingly driven by civilian technologies that can be rapidly adapted for military use, such as AI and cloud computing. The discussion stressed that Europe must invest in its own industrial base, speed up technology adoption, and strengthen cooperation between civil and defence actors to close capability gaps. Participants called for a "European way" of dual use, grounded in ethics, collaboration, and trust, while ensuring security, interoperability, and alignment with EU values. Strengthened EU-NATO cooperation was also seen as vital to harness shared competencies, streamline procurement, and provide a stronger demand signal to industry.

> Dual use solutions are becoming really essential when we're looking at our future military capabilities and the future mix of the force. What we're also experiencing and seeing, [as you also rightly mentioned] ,is that we also live in a time that we like calling a technology adoption race.
>
> **Nikos LOUTAS**

## Moderator

**Marc LEMAÎTRE**
*Director General | European Commission*

## Speakers

**Eszter LAKOS**
*Member of the European Parliament | European Parliament*

**Nikos LOUTAS ZITELLI**
*Director of Innovation | NATO*

**Marc DARMON**
*Senior Vice President | Thales*



Image order: top to bottom and left to right

# AI-powered research: a competitiveness opportunity for Europe



Artificial intelligence holds transformative power to boost Europe's research capabilities and global competitiveness. Strategic investments in AI infrastructure, like AI factories and gigafactories, are essential to drive innovation and safeguard technological sovereignty.

On top of reshaping the global innovation landscape, AI is transforming scientific discovery, helping scientists decode the brain, discover new materials and antibiotics, or decoding archaeological inscriptions. This session explored how to improve Europe's competitiveness and increase its strategic autonomy by leveraging artificial intelligence (AI) to transform research and innovation.

The session also informed about the then upcoming European Strategy for AI in Science that would lay the groundwork for the Resource for AI Science in Europe (RAISE) as its flagship initiative.

*To secure Europe's place in the AI race, we must be bold and work together in a human-centred, ethical, and trustworthy approach.*

**Henna VIRKKUNEN**

*Prioritization needs to be on sovereignty for sensitive usage a nd the sufficient degree of EU independence and autonomy is crucial throughout the entire digital value chain, including the areas vlike cloud and chip.*

**Sabine KLAUKE**

## Moderator

**Marc LEMAÎTRE**
*Director General | European Commission*

## Speakers

**Henna VIRKKUNEN**
*Executive Vice-President | European Commission*

**Sabine KLAUKE**
*Head of Digital Design Manufacturing and Services "Next Gen" | AIRBUS*

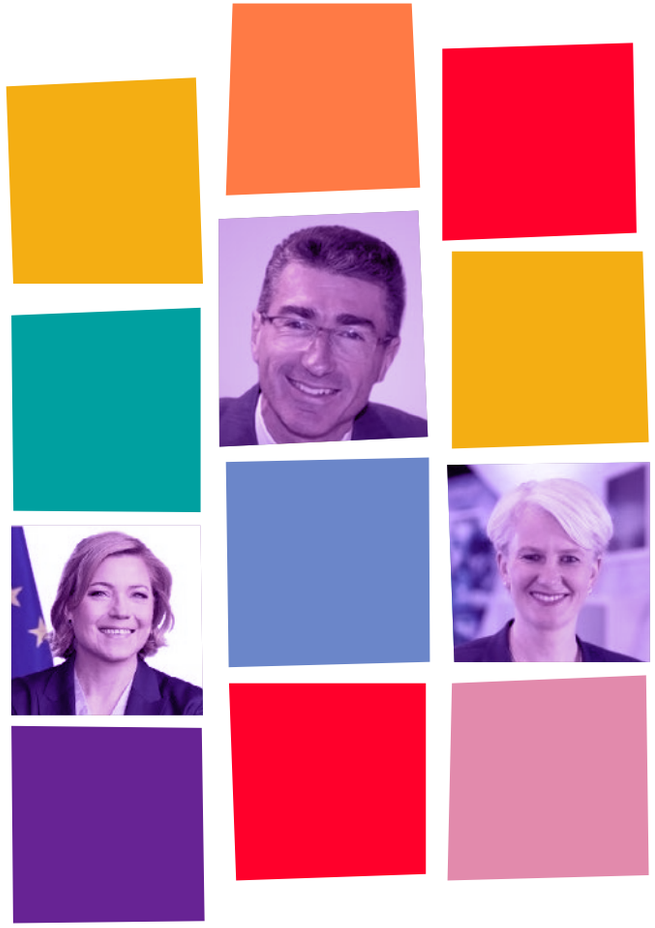


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Live Sessions
17
SEPT
2025

# Making the EU the most attractive place for Life Sciences

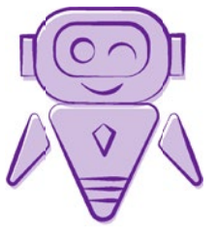


This session brought together key stakeholders in European life sciences, from industry, academia, patient organisation and an SME. Speakers discussed the role of Europe as leader in the life sciences and how to jointly implement the Strategy, to deliver on our competitiveness, green and digital goals and improve people's quality of life. Speakers emphasised the importance of developing coherent, innovation-friendly regulations, accessing EU and private funding to scale up innovations and ensuring end-user involvement in the development of new technologies.

RTD Deputy Director-General Joanna Drake and panellists agreed on the need for stronger collaboration — both internally at the Commission, to align policies, funding, and activities, and externally, to engage stakeholders and overcome shared challenges. They recognised that achieving the ambitions of the Strategy for European Life Sciences will require mobilising all available expertise, resources, and partnerships, both within Europe and beyond.

*The life sciences sector is a strategic pillar for Europe's future prosperity, for driving innovation, for driving competitiveness, and also for the well-being of society.*

**Joanna DRAKE**



## Moderator

**Joanna DRAKE**
*Deputy Director General | European Commission*

## Speakers

**Giulia MENICHETTI**
*Faculty Member and Investigator | Brigham and Women's Hospital, Harvard Medical School*

**Rosa CASTRO**
*Public Affairs Director | EURORDIS-Rare Diseases Europe*

**Claire SKENTELBERY**
*Director General | EuropaBio*



Image order: top to bottom and left to right

# Securing Europe's place at the forefront of discovery

EUROPEAN RESEARCH & INNOVATION DAYS 2025

This session explored how sustained investment in people, ideas, and innovation pathways can secure Europe's scientific leadership. Speakers highlighted the pivotal role of the European Research Council (ERC) in supporting frontier research driven by scientific excellence and independence.

They underlined that the ERC model—by scientists, for scientists—has enabled groundbreaking discoveries, talent development, and interdisciplinary progress. However, only a limited number of high-quality proposals can currently be funded, calling for increased investment and better long-term support. The discussion also stressed the need to connect fundamental research with innovation, encourage risk-taking, and attract global talent. Strengthening STEM education, promoting women's participation, and fostering international collaboration were seen as essential to ensure that Europe remains a place where knowledge, curiosity, and creativity can thrive.

*The ERC model—by scientists, for scientists—has been key to enabling groundbreaking discoveries, nurturing talent, and fostering interdisciplinary progress.*

**Prof. Conny AERTS**

## Moderator

**Méabh MC MAHON**
*Anchor | Euronews*

## Speakers

**Conny AERTS**
*Professor of astrophysics | KU Leuven, Belgium*

**Dirk INZÉ**
*Emeritus Science Director | VIB, Belgium*

**Jan LAGERWALL**
*Professor of physics | University of Luxembourg*

Image order: top to bottom and left to right



# Strengthening the EU clinical research ecosystem

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The session emphasized the pivotal role of clinical research in developing new therapies and health solutions across Europe. It highlighted the necessity of building and sustaining a resilient and strengthened European clinical research ecosystem. The speakers stressed the importance of strengthening it through embracing sustainable investments, research infrastructures and advancing digital innovation.

Panellists called for increased coordination, technological advancements, and the integration of clinical trials into national health systems to ensure preparedness and equal opportunities for all.
The session concluded with a call for a dynamic, inclusive, and harmonized EU clinical research ecosystem to effectively address global health challenges and fortify Europe's research leadership, aligning with the overarching EU Life Sciences strategy and the Clinical Research Investment Plan flagship.

*A single market approach to maintain Europe's competitive position as a hub for research and health innovations.*

**Isaac MIDDELMANN**



## Moderator

**Maria Pilar AGUAR FERNANDEZ**
*Director - People: Health and Society Directorate | European Commission*

## Speakers

**Isaac MIDDELMANN**
*Accelerator Director | EIT Health*

**Michael MAKANGA**
*Executive Director | Global Health EDCTP3 Joint Undertaking*

**Evelina TACCONELLI**
*Professor of Infectious Diseases and Chief Scientific Officer | University of Verona / ECRAID*

Image order: top to bottom and left to right



# Let’s talk business: how to commercialise breakthrough research

EUROPEAN RESEARCH & INNOVATION DAYS 2025

Europe’s scientific excellence drives groundbreaking discoveries every day, yet transforming these breakthroughs into market-ready innovations remains a major challenge. From managing intellectual property to attracting investment and talent, the path from lab to market is complex and often fragmented. That’s why this session, explored how to strengthen Europe’s innovation ecosystem and unlock the full potential of its researchers and entrepreneurs.

The discussion bridged policy ambitions and real-world experience, with experts from academia, research organisations, and industry sharing how closer collaboration can foster entrepreneurship and accelerate commercialisation. Speakers highlighted the need for fast, fair deal-making and high-quality patents to reduce risk and attract investors, especially in fast-evolving fields such as AI. The innovative virtual shares model emerged as a promising way to simplify IP transfer and ensure fair returns for both universities and startups. This pairs with the importance of supporting founders throughout their entrepreneurial journey, from early research to scaling up. The European Commission’s  EU Startup Fund was mentioned as a key opportunity to fuel growth and strengthen Europe’s competitiveness on the global stage. Closing the debate, a strong call to action emerges: to invest in entrepreneurial skills, cross-border collaboration, and smarter funding pathways that can turn Europe’s cutting-edge research into global success stories.

*Collaboration beats fragmentation. We must scale to critical mass. Mass is very, very important. And we must bring corporates very early to spin-offs so they will become investable and successful*

**Harald HOLZER**

### Moderator

**Maria Cristina RUSSO**
*Director for Prosperity | European Commission*

### Speakers

**Gilles REQUENA**
*Chief Patent Research and Policy Officer | European Patent Office*

**Harald HOLZER**
*CEO Innovation- and Startup Center | TU Darmstadt | HIGHEST*

**Anne LANE**
*CEO | UCL Business Ltd*



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# Cities of tomorrow

EUROPEAN RESEARCH & INNOVATION DAYS 2025

The session “Cities of Tomorrow” highlighted the pivotal role of cities and regions in driving Europe’s green and circular transition. Pirita Lindholm, Director of ERRIN, opened by stressing that local actors make things happen by turningEuropean ambitions into practical solutions. She called for stronger empowerment in view of the Clean Industrial Deal and upcoming policy frameworks.

Mayors from Leuven, Vaasa and Guimarães explained how circularity is embedded in their climate neutrality and adaptation strategies. Thomas Van Oppens, Deputy Mayor of Leuven, showcased their Materials Bank as a flagship for local reuse, Tomas Häyry, Mayor of Vaasa emphasised the industrial partnerships and cross-border cooperation, and Adelina Pinto, Deputy Mayor of Guimarães, underlined citizen engagement and education as key enablers of systemic change. Minna Martikainen, Rector of the University of Vaasa, illustrated how academia can link research and industry to accelerate innovation. Speakers stressed the need for place-based innovation ecosystems and adequate financing tools, supported by EU flagship initiatives such as the Circular Cities and Regions Initiative (CCRI). Circularity emerged as both an environmental imperative and a lever for resilience, competitiveness and local leadership.

*Circularity has become ‘The’ building block to reach our climate neutrality goals. Through our materials bank, we aim to transform 8,000 tons of built materials for local reuse by 2030*

**Thomas VAN OPPENS**

## Moderator

**Pirita LINDHOLM**
*Director | ERRIN - European Regions Research and Innovation Network*

## Speakers

**Tomas HÄYRY**
*Mayor | City of Vaasa*

**Minna MARTIKAINEN**
*Rector | University Of Vaasa*

**Thomas VAN OPPENS**
*Deputy Mayor | City of Leuven*

**Adelina PINTO**
*Deputy Mayor | Municipality of Guimarães*

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# Building the Resource for AI Science in Europe (RAISE)

EUROPEAN RESEARCH & INNOVATION DAYS 2025

This session explored the transformative potential of pooling of resources to advance AI-driven scientific discovery in Europe.

With artificial intelligence (AI) reshaping science, strategic collaboration is critical to achieve sufficient scale, address fragmentation, and align with common EU research objectives. From accelerating drug discovery to decoding climate patterns, AI-driven science has the potential to solve humanity's greatest challenges. Yet, to realise this vision, we need a coordinated effort to pool resources, data, and expertise across borders.

The session informed about a new EU initiative, RAISE (Resource for AI Science in Europe) as an instrument for pooling and aligning essential resources from the EU, Member States, and private sector towards strategic goals. Such resources include computational power, data, excellence & talent and research funding. Panellists discussed how RAISE could foster interdisciplinary collaboration between AI research (science for AI) and its application across diverse scientific fields (AI in science), strengthen cross-border synergies, enhance accessibility to high-performance computing, and build networks of excellence to accelerate breakthroughs.

*Let's double down on Europe's tradition of open science and open innovation*

**Jessica MONTGOMERY**

### Moderator

**Maria Cristina RUSSO**
*Director for Prosperity | European Commission*

### Speakers

**Jessica MONTGOMERY**
*Executive Director of the Accelerate Programme for Scientific Discovery | University of Cambridge*

**Fabian J. THEIS**
*Head of the Computational Health Centre | AI Helmholtz Munich*

**Petra DALUNDE**
*Co-director Swedish AI Factory MIMER at RISE Coordinator Formal Test & Evaluation of AI | Research Institutes of Sweden RISE*



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# Aliens, black holes, travel – making science exciting

EUROPEAN RESEARCH & INNOVATION DAYS 2025

Curiosity drives discovery, yet too often, science feels distant or intimidating to young minds. The session “Aliens, Black Holes, and Space Travel” at the European Research and Innovation Days 2025 explored how to make science both engaging and accessible, turning complex ideas into sparks of inspiration for the next generation.

Humour, storytelling, and creativity can transform the way science is communicated, helping children connect with topics that might otherwise feel out of reach. The discussion also tackled the limitations of traditional science education, which can struggle to link classroom learning with students’ real interests and lived experiences. Introducing the concept of science capital, speakers emphasised that young people need to see themselves represented in science to imagine their own place within it. The conversation moved then from theory to practice, highlighting the power of interactive learning and diverse role models in breaking stereotypes and opening new pathways into STEM. The session closed with a shared ambition: to build a culture where science feels relevant, exciting, and open to everyone, inspiring the explorers, inventors, and innovators of tomorrow.

Moderator

**Méabh MC MAHON**
*Anchor | Euronews*

Speakers

**Lucy HAWKING**
*Author and science communicator*

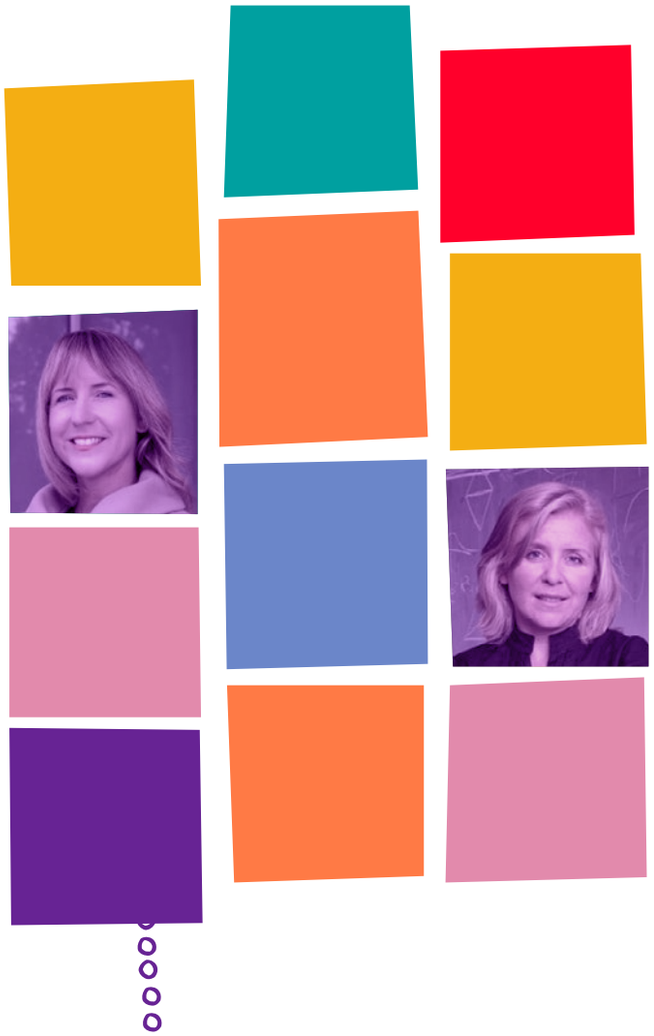


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*I have been enormously privileged, through my work, to be able to contribute to our understanding of the universe. But it would be an empty universe indeed, if it were not for the people I love, and who love me. We are all time travelers, churning together into the future. But let us work together to make that future a place we want to visit. Be brave, be determined, overcome the odds. It can be done.*

**Lucy HAWKING**

# Driving R&I forward: roadblocks and accelerators for the EU automotive competitiveness



The session emphasized the need for stronger collaboration between policymakers and the automotive industry to shape Europe's research and innovation agenda. Key themes included energy security, resilient supply chains, and the creation of favorable conditions for scaling up innovation.

Public-private partnerships and pooling of resources were highlighted as essential to support emerging technologies such as zero-emission vehicles, artificial intelligence, and Software-Defined Vehicles. Technology openness was seen as a critical enabler for industrial flexibility and growth. Scaling challenges were identified as major barriers, requiring clear strategic roadmaps and coordinated efforts. Ensuring manufacturing capacity within Europe, especially for batteries, was considered vital to reduce dependency on external suppliers and enhance competitiveness. The session reaffirmed the automotive sector's strategic importance to the EU economy and called for targeted R&I investments, regulatory alignment, and industrial cooperation to secure Europe's leadership in a competitive, sustainable, and innovation-driven automotive future.

## Moderator

**Méabh MC MAHON**
*Anchor | Euronews*

## Speakers

**Ekaterina ZAHARIEVA**
*European Commissioner for Startups, Research and Innovation | European Commission*

**Yann VINCENT**
*Chief Executive Officer | Automotive Cells Company SE (ACC)*

**Joachim POST**
*Mitglied des Vorstands | BMW AG Entwicklung*

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# ERA Act, are we brave enough?

EUROPEAN RESEARCH & INNOVATION DAYS 2024

This session explored the ambition, challenges and political significance of the forthcoming European Research Area Act (ERA Act), and how legislation could bring us closer to completing the Single Market with a “fifth freedom”: the free circulation of researchers, knowledge and technology.

The discussion focused on how the ERA Act could provide the legislative backbone to move from voluntary coordination to shared, enforceable commitments for the implementation of a truly integrated European Research Area. Panellists agreed that binding measures are needed to reduce persistent fragmentation, align national efforts, and improve research careers and mobility across borders. The debate also underlined the balance between ambition and realism – ensuring that the Act respects subsidiarity and national diversity while setting common standards for openness, excellence and freedom of scientific research. Participants highlighted the need for sustained investment and better coordination, as well as clear monitoring mechanisms to ensure delivery. A recurring theme was the importance of political will and shared ownership to turn the “fifth freedom” into a tangible reality for Europe’s researchers and innovators.

*We want to create not only these boundary conditions, but an atmosphere of mutual trust so that there’s a lot of collaboration.*

**Robbert DIJKGRAAF**

## Moderator

**Signe RATSO**
*Deputy Director General | European Commission*

## Speakers

**Ekaterina ZAHARIEVA**
*European Commissioner for Startups, Research and Innovation | European Commission*

**Kurt DEKETELAERE**
*Secretary-General | League of European Research Universities (LERU)*

**Robbert DIJKGRAAF**
*President-Elect (ISC) and University Professor (UvA) | Internat*

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# Choose Europe for Science

EUROPEAN RESEARCH & INNOVATION DAYS 2025

Europe's strength in research lies not only in its discoveries but in the people who make them possible. This session explored how to position Europe as a top destination for global scientific talent, built on trust, excellence, and opportunity. Speakers underlined the importance of attracting and retaining researchers by creating high-quality, stable career paths, especially for early-career scientists, backed by clear political commitment and long-term investment.

The conversation focused on tackling brain drain and building a vibrant ecosystem that supports researchers at every stage, through initiatives such as scholarships, research chairs, and dedicated mobility schemes. The session also celebrated the collaborative spirit of European science, where openness, interdisciplinarity, and cross-border cooperation remain key to progress. Programmes like the Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions were cited as models for fostering community and exchange among researchers, leading to a shared vision closing the session: to make Europe not just a place to work, but a place to belong. A true home for scientific talent from around the world.

*We know that Europe is the most robust and the most reliable zone at the world level and also the most efficient where the resources evolve due to our diversity.*

**Manuel HEITOR**

## Moderator

**Magda DE CARLI**
*Head of Unit and Deputy Director | European Commission*

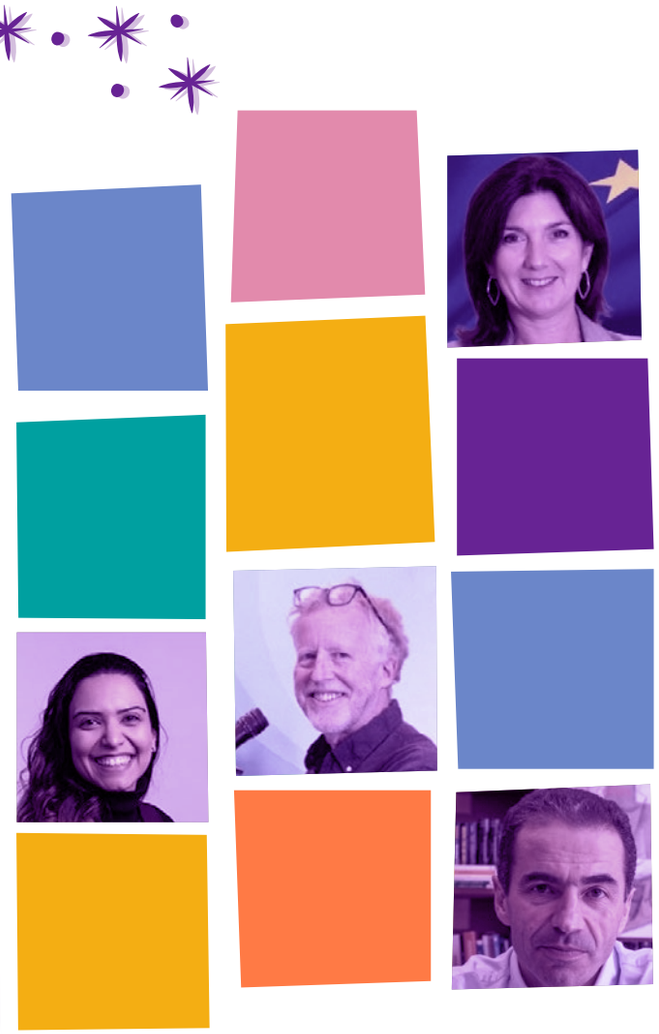
## Speakers

**Ana Paula MENDONÇA**
*Researcher and Innovation Consultant | University of Padova*

**Andrew LIEBHOLD**
*Chief Scientist | Forest Invasion Synthesis Centre*

**Manuel HEITOR**
*Professor, director technology policy laboratory | IN+, Center for Innovation, Tech. & Policy Research, @IST lisbon, University of Lisbon*

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# Protecting academic freedom worldwide: the role of Science Diplomacy and Research Security

EUROPEAN RESEARCH & INNOVATION DAYS 2025

The session started with an analysis of the geopolitical panorama which is characterised by a zero-sum view of the world with international cooperation increasingly seen as a a transactional business.

At the same time, universities are being attacked as elitist institutions with the primary target being precisely those scientific areas where science had the biggest impact (e.g. climate, health). In view of developments in the US and China, the EU plays a key role as a guardian of academic freedom, with many countries looking at Europe as a reliable partner. It is essential that scientific superpowers are democracies and that democracies are scientific superpowers. This is why Europe needs to play a strong global role in science diplomacy. In this context, the session discussed the concrete example of cooperation with North Korea, where a research project on the Mount Paektu volcano continued despite sanctions. One of the lessons learnt was: "We went as scientists to North Korea and came back as science diplomats.

*Academic and scientific freedom are ingrained in the EU's core values and are among the key assets that attract researchers to Europe.*

**Nienke BUISMAN**

### Moderator

**Nienke BUISMAN**
*Head of Unit | European Commission*

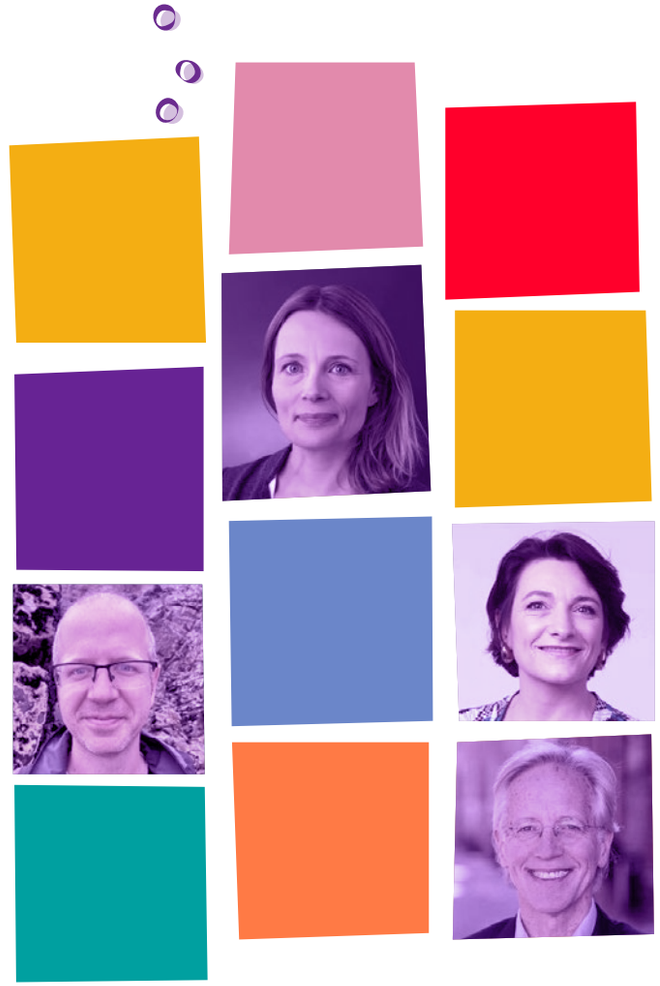
### Speakers

**James HAMMOND**
*Professor of Geophysics | Birkbeck, University of London*

**Stéphanie BALME**
*Director of CERI | SCIENCES PO PARIS*

**Robbert DIJKGRAAF**
*President-Elect (ISC) and University Professor (UvA) | International Science Council and UvA*

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# €820 billion on the table: can Europe afford to ignore the Gender Gap in STEM careers?



This session highlighted the need to close the gender gap in STEM to achieve Europe's competitiveness goals. The title echoes a study Cities led by the European Institute for Gender Equality, which estimates that closing the gap could add €650-820 billion to the EU's GDP by 2050. With only 22% of ICT specialists and 9% of patent applicants being women, experts discussed challenges and opportunities.

The session aimed to inspire the implementation of EU initiatives like the Union of Skills and the EU Start-up and Scale-up Strategy to create a more inclusive environment and promote gender equality in research and innovation.
The speakers particularly emphasised the importance of work-life balance for working parents, the need to shift from mentoring to active sponsorship, and the essential role women play in bringing diverse perspectives and ideas to science and innovation, ultimately driving more powerful and impactful solutions.

*We need to tell women that the digital business, the AI business, is looking for them. They need them. They need their talent. They need their emotional intelligence to make the technology serve the society.*

**Věra JOUROVÁ**

## Moderator

**Théophane HARTMANN**
*Tech journalist | Euractiv*

## Speakers

**Věra JOUROVÁ**
*Vice-Rector for the Development of Human Resources and New Technologies; in charge of managing the agenda of the Public Relations | Charles University, Czech Republic*

**Michiel SCHEFFER**
*President of the Board | European Innovation Council*

**Ann VAN DER JEUGD**
*Institute Coordinator - Outgoing President | LBI, Leuven Brain Institute - BeWiSe, Belgian Women in Science*

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# Time's Up: Urgent Action Needed to Achieve the 3% R&D Investment Target

EUROPEAN RESEARCH & INNOVATION DAYS 2025

The session was moderated by Marc Lemaître, Director-General of DG R&I. Teresa Czerwińska, Vice President of the European Investment Bank (EIB), delivered the keynote speech, emphasizing the need to improve European competitiveness through increased investment in R&D. The panel discussion featured contributions from Lina Gálvez, Member of the European Parliament; Markku Markkula, Vice-President of the Committee of the Regions; and Alexandre Affre, Deputy Director-General of Business Europe.

Lina Gálvez highlighted the importance of strengthening incentives and enhancing accountability and transparency to harmonize national R&D investment strategies with the 3% target. Markku Markkula shared Finland's experience, stressing the need for human capital investment and bold EU collaboration. Alexandre Affre discussed the alignment of Business Europe's investments with the EU's R&D goals, emphasizing the need for public funding synergies and simplification.

The session concluded with a call to action, underscoring the necessity to do more, better, and together to boost public and private R&D investments in Europe.

*There is an urgency to do better, to do together and do together in the field of R&I..*

**Marc LEMAITRE**

## Moderator

**Marc LEMAÎTRE**
*Director General | European Commission*

## Speakers

**Lina GALVEZ**
*Member of the European Parliament | European Parliament*

**Teresa CZERWINSKA**
*Vice-President | European Investment Bank*

**Alexandre AFFRE**
*Deputy Director General | BusinessEurope*

**Markku MARKKULA**
*Vice-President, CoR | CoR*



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# CLOSING REMARKS

EUROPEAN RESEARCH & INNOVATION DAYS 2025

Conclude the European Research & Innovation Days 2025 with a reflective closing session that will recap the highlights, key insights, and outcomes from the event. The session will emphasize Europe's commitment to advancing scientific excellence and innovation. Participants will leave with a clear understanding of upcoming priorities, opportunities for collaboration, and how the EU research community is driving change across society and industry.

*It is now more important than ever to support research for solutions to the most pressing mid- and long-term challenges of our times.*

**Marc LEMAITRE**

Moderator

**Marc LEMAÎTRE**
*Director General for Research and Innovation | European Commission*

**Méabh MC MAHON**
*Anchor | Euronews*

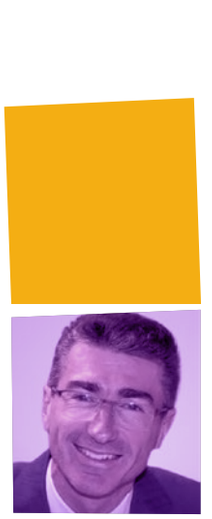








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### EU open data

The portal data.europa.eu provides access to open datasets from the EU institutions, bodies and agencies. These can be downloaded and reused for free, for both commercial and non-commercial purposes. The portal also provides access to a wealth of datasets from European countries.

European Research and Innovation Days is the European Commission's annual flagship Research and Innovation event, bringing together policymakers, researchers, entrepreneurs and the public to debate and shape the future of research and innovation in Europe and beyond. 2025 was the 6th edition.

The event took place between 16 and 17 September and attracted 5 300 onsite participants from 23 different countries, with almost 10 000 joining online.

This conference report contains summaries, quotes and images from the two-day event. You are welcome to explore all live sessions and workshops on the EU Science & Innovation YouTube channel.

Research and Innovation policy

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